Shooters Pool League Rules & Bylaws

2026 Rules & Bylaws

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League Structure & Rosters

Except where specifically modified by these Shooters Pool League local rules, games shall be governed by the current Official Rules of CueSports International (CSI) as used by the BCA Pool League. If a Shooters local rule directly conflicts with a CSI rule, the Shooters local rule controls for Shooters league play.

Each team consists of a minimum of 3 players and a maximum of 6 players, but only 3 players will play per night. Nine games are played each night. Each shooter pays $5 in the team envelope on the night they shoot. To be eligible to play, a player must be on the team roster. Roster additions are permitted only through the end of the first half of the season. During that period, a team with fewer than six players may add players until the six-player maximum is reached. A team already carrying six players may add a new player only if another player is first removed from the roster. No players may be added to or substituted onto a team roster after the conclusion of the first half. The League Statistician must be notified of and approve all roster changes before the new player may compete. Use of an ineligible or non-roster player will result in forfeiture of that player's games. The Statistician must also be notified before a player who has previously played in the Shooters Pool League joins a team. Players must confirm their desire to play for the team with the Statistician. Member names and contact information are confidential, available only to league officers, and may be used only for league business. All players must complete a registration form. By joining a team, the completed registration form constitutes the player's agreement to play for the sponsor location listed on that form. For lineup posting, the visiting captain posts the first shooter, the home captain posts the next shooter, and the teams alternate until all positions are filled.

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Rules of Play

1. OBJECT OF THE GAME. Eight Ball is a call shot game played with a cue ball and fifteen object balls, numbered 1 through 15. One player must pocket balls of the group numbered 1 through 7 solid colors, while the other player has 9 through 15 stripes. THE PLAYER POCKETING THEIR GROUP FIRST AND THEN LEGALLY POCKETING THE 8 BALL WINS THE GAME.

2. CALL SHOT. Obvious balls and pockets do not have to be called. If the opponent is unsure of the intended shot, the opponent may ask which ball and pocket are intended. Non-obvious shots, including banks and combinations, require the shooter to designate the intended object ball and pocket. It is not necessary to call cushions, kisses, caroms, or other shot details. If the called object ball is not legally pocketed in the called pocket, the shooter's inning ends; this alone is not a loss of game. When shooting the 8-ball, the intended pocket must be clearly designated. Pocketing the 8-ball in an uncalled or incorrectly called pocket is a loss of game.

3. RACKING THE BALLS. The balls are racked in a triangle at the foot of the table with the 8-ball in the center of the triangle, the first ball of the rack on the foot spot, a stripe ball in one corner of the rack and a solid ball in the other corner. The non-breaking opponent or a member of the non-breaking opponent's team is responsible for racking the balls. The breaking opponent has the authority to review the rack prior to performing the break shot.

4. BREAK. The score sheet has the player shown who breaks.

5. JUMP AND MASSE SHOT FOUL. While cue ball fouls only is the rule of play when a match is not presided over by a referee, a player should be aware that it will be considered a cue ball foul if during an attempt to jump, curve or masse the cue ball over or around an impeding numbered ball that is not a legal object ball, the impeding ball moves, regardless of whether it was moved by a hand, cue stick follow through or bridge.

6. LEGAL BREAK SHOT. Defined. To execute a legal break, the breaker with the cue ball behind the head string, must either 1, pocket a ball, or 2, drive at least four numbered balls to the rail. If they fail to make a legal break, it is a foul, and the incoming player has the option of 1 accepting the table in position and shooting, or 2, having the balls re-racked and having the option of shooting the opening break themselves or allowing the offending player to rebreak.

7. SCRATCH ON A LEGAL BREAK. If the breaker scratches on an otherwise legal break, it is a foul. All object balls pocketed remain pocketed except as specifically provided for the 8-ball in Rule 8. The table remains open, and the incoming player receives cue ball in hand behind the head string. If the breaker pockets the 8-ball and also scratches or otherwise illegally pockets the cue ball on the same break, the breaker loses the game and the final score is recorded as 10-0 in favor of the opponent.

8. 8 BALL POCKETED ON THE BREAK. If the breaker pockets the 8-ball on the break without committing a scratch, the breaker wins the game. The final score for that game will be recorded as 10-7 in favor of the breaker. If the breaker pockets the 8-ball and also scratches or otherwise illegally pockets the cue ball on the same break, the breaker loses the game and the final score is recorded as 10-0 in favor of the opponent.

9. OPEN TABLE. Defined. The table is open when the choice of groups stripes or solids has not yet been determined. When the table is open, it is legal to hit a solid first to make a stripe or vice-versa. Note: The table is always open immediately after the break shot. When the table is open it is legal to hit any solid or stripe first, pocketing the called stripe or solid. However, when the table is open and the 8 ball is the first ball contacted, no stripe or solid may be scored in favor of the shooter. The shooter loses their turn and any balls pocketed remain pocketed, and the incoming player addresses the balls with the table still open. Striking the 8-ball first on an open table is a foul. All illegally pocketed balls remain pocketed.

10. CHOICE OF GROUP. The choice of stripes or solids is not determined on the break even if balls are made from only one or both groups. THE TABLE IS ALWAYS OPEN IMMEDIATELY AFTER THE BREAK SHOT. The choice of group is determined only when a player legally pockets a called object ball after the break shot.

11. LEGAL SHOT. Defined. On all shots except on the break and when the table is open, the shooter must hit one of their group of balls first and 1, pocket a numbered ball, or 2, cause the cue ball or any numbered ball to contact a rail.

12. SAFETY SHOT. For tactical reasons a player may choose to pocket an obvious object ball and discontinue their turn at the table by declaring safety in advance. A safety shot is defined as a legal shot. If the shooting player intends to play safe by pocketing an obvious object ball, then prior to the shot, they must declare a safety to their opponent. If this is NOT done, and one of the shooter's object balls is pocketed, the shooter will be required to shoot again. Any ball pocketed on a safety shot remains pocketed.

13. SCORING. A player continues shooting until failing to legally pocket a ball of their group or until the inning otherwise ends under these rules. After legally pocketing all balls of their group, the player shoots the 8-ball. Each object ball is worth 1 point and the 8-ball is worth 3 points, for a 10-point scoring system. A sample score sheet will be included in each team's folder. The home team keeps the official score sheet. A round is complete after all 3 players scheduled for that round have played.

14. HANDICAP. Prior to each match, each team’s total skill rating will be calculated by adding the skill ratings of the three players scheduled to compete. The difference between the two teams’ total skill ratings will determine the match handicap. The team with the lower total skill rating will be awarded handicap points equal to that difference. Handicap points are applied only to the final total match score and have no effect on individual games, individual game scores, or player skill ratings.

15. FOUL PENALTY. Unless another penalty is specifically stated, a foul ends the shooter's inning and the incoming player receives cue ball in hand anywhere on the table, except where the break rules specifically provide otherwise. With cue ball in hand, the player may place the cue ball by hand or with the cue stick, but any legal forward stroke that contacts the cue ball begins the shot. There is no minimum distance that the cue ball must travel for a foul or legal stroke to be recognized. The three-consecutive-fouls loss-of-game rule does not apply to 8-ball.

16. COMBINATION SHOTS. Combination and carom shots are allowed. After groups have been established, the cue ball must first contact a legal object ball from the shooter's group. While the table is open, the 8-ball may be used in a combination but may not be the first ball contacted by the cue ball. When the 8-ball is the shooter's legal object ball, the cue ball must contact the 8-ball first; the 8-ball may then carom off another ball before entering the properly called pocket.

17. ILLEGALLY POCKETED BALLS. An object ball is considered to be illegally pocketed when 1, that object ball has been pocketed on the same shot a foul is committed, or 2, the called ball did not go in the designated pocket, or 3, a safety is called prior to the shot. Illegally pocketed balls remain pocketed. Illegally pocketing the 8 ball is a loss of game.

18. OBJECT BALLS JUMPED OFF THE TABLE. If any object ball is jumped off the table, it is a foul and loss of turn, unless it is the 8 ball, which is a loss of game. Any jumped object balls are spotted in numerical order according to General Rules for spotting balls.

19. PLAYING THE 8 BALL. When the 8-ball is the shooter's legal object ball, a foul that does not pocket or jump the 8-ball is not, by itself, a loss of game; the inning ends and the opponent receives cue ball in hand. It is a loss of game if the shooter illegally pockets the 8-ball, pockets it in the wrong or uncalled pocket, pockets it while it is not the legal object ball, or jumps it off the table. The cue ball must contact the 8-ball first on a legal 8-ball shot, but the 8-ball may carom off another ball before entering the called pocket.

Match Administration

20. TIMEOUTS AND COACHING. Each player is allowed two (2) coaching timeouts per game, with each timeout limited to two (2) minutes. Only one designated coach may advise the shooter during a timeout. The coach may discuss the shot and point to locations on the table but may not touch any ball, move equipment on the playing surface, or execute a practice stroke that contacts a ball. The scorekeeper tracks timeouts. Exceeding the two-minute limit after a warning is a foul. All coaching must conclude before the player makes their shot, and the designated coach must step away from the table before the player begins the shot.

21. SHOT TIME LIMIT. Players are expected to shoot within one (1) minute. The one-minute limit is not automatically enforced on every shot. If a player is believed to be playing excessively slowly, either team captain may request that the shot clock be placed in effect. Once timing is announced, the player has one minute to complete each shot. The scorekeeper or team captain should give a warning as the limit approaches. Failure to complete the shot within the announced time limit is a foul.

22. FORFEIT. A player who is not present when their game is called has a 15-minute grace period to arrive. If the player does not arrive within that period, the game is forfeited and scored 10-0. A forfeited game does not count as a game played or as an individual win or loss. Record FL (Forfeit Loss) for the forfeiting player/team and FW (Forfeit Win) for the opponent. If the player arrives later, they may play any remaining scheduled games that have not already been forfeited.

23. LOSS OF GAME. A player loses the game if the player: (a) fouls while pocketing the 8-ball; (b) pockets the 8-ball on the same stroke as the last ball of the player's group; (c) jumps the 8-ball off the table, except as addressed by the break rules; (d) pockets the 8-ball in a pocket other than the properly called pocket; or (e) pockets the 8-ball when it is not the legal object ball. A non-obvious 8-ball shot must be called. An infraction must be raised before the next shot is taken unless the nature of the infraction makes immediate recognition impossible.

24. DISTURBED BALLS. The league follows current CSI rules for accidentally moved or disturbed balls. A player must not intentionally touch or move any ball in play except when permitted for cue ball in hand. If a ball is accidentally moved, play should stop when necessary so the captains or an agreed neutral person can restore the ball as closely as possible to its original position. If the disturbance affects the outcome of the shot, contacts the cue ball, or creates another foul under CSI rules, the appropriate foul penalty applies.

25. DOUBLE HITS, PUSH SHOTS, AND FROZEN BALLS. Double hits and push shots are fouls. When the cue ball is frozen to or extremely close to an object ball, players must use a legal stroke consistent with current CSI rules. When a legal object ball is frozen to a cushion, merely contacting that already-frozen cushion does not by itself satisfy the requirement to drive a ball to a cushion after contact; a ball must be legally pocketed or the cue ball or another object ball must contact a cushion as required by CSI rules.

26. STALEMATE. If both players agree, or the captains determine, that the table position is not progressing and continued attempts are unlikely to change the position without intentional loss, a stalemate may be declared. The game is re-racked and replayed, with the player who broke the original game breaking again.

27. OUTSIDE INTERFERENCE. If balls are moved or play is affected by a person or event not involved in the game, play stops. The balls should be restored as closely as possible to their prior positions by agreement of the players/captains, and play resumes without penalty to the shooter unless the shooter caused the interference.

28. RULES DISPUTES, PROTESTS, AND PLAYING ORDER. Players should stop play immediately when a rules dispute arises. The two team captains should first attempt to resolve the issue using these local rules and the current CSI rules. If the captains cannot agree, the game should be completed under protest and the disputed facts documented on the score sheet for League Board review. A player may not intentionally play out of the posted order. If the wrong player begins a game, the captains should correct the lineup before the next game begins; any unresolved eligibility or playing-order dispute is subject to League Board review.

Season, Fees & Payouts

29. PLAYOFFS. Playoffs will be played as a regular match; the team with highest score wins. A player must play at least 16 games (4 league nights) to qualify for the playoffs.

30. PAYMENT. The Treasurer will announce the approved method of payment. Each player scheduled to play pays $5.00. A tracking sheet will be available for team captains. Teams remain responsible for fees associated with forfeited games. With 3 players competing in the standard nightly format, the team owes $15 per night. Any money owed may be deducted from team winnings in each half.

31. SPONSORS. The sponsorship fee is $250 per season. Sponsors may pay $125 prior to the start of each half. Sponsors are awarded a $25 discount per half, totaling a $50 discount for the season, when the season sponsorship is paid in full prior to the start of the second half. A sponsor qualifying for the full-season discount will therefore pay $200 for the season. Any money owed may be deducted from team winnings in each half.

32. PAYOUTS. Team payouts are during the “MID-SEASON PARTY” & “END OF SEASON PARTY”.

33. PLAYER RATINGS. Each player will be assigned a skill rating calculated by dividing the player's total points earned by the total number of games played. A player will receive an official skill rating after completing three (3) matches, or nine (9) games. In the event of a forfeited game, a score of 10-0 will be awarded; however, the forfeited game will not be added to either player's total games played and therefore will not affect either player's skill rating average.

Bylaws

Shooters Pool League is a voluntary, not-for-profit sports league based in the Cleveland, Ohio metropolitan area for the purpose of building the LGBTQ+ community through the sport of billiards. The league provides for up to seven elected officer positions: Commissioner, Secretary, Statistician, Treasurer, Tournament Director, Events Director, and At-Large Officer.

Officers & Responsibilities

Commissioner (If elected)

Duties: Responsible for general leadership of the organization, proper stewardship, and healthy growth of the league. Oversees "rules of the game" with the intent to ensure that the game is fair and fun for all players. Makes final decisions on how a rule is interpreted in case of a dispute.

Current Officer: See the current League Board contact list.

Secretary (If elected)

Duties: Ensures accurate recordkeeping, effective and prompt communications to all league constituents, and coordinates proper organizational registration paperwork required by any governmental, non-profit, or private entity. Coordinates meeting agendas for any meeting of the organization along with all relevant dates and calendars needed by the league.

Current Officer: See the current League Board contact list.

Statistician (If elected)

Duties: Responsible for all aspects of accurate scorekeeping of games and ensures that overall statistics are computed accurately and distributed to members in an efficient manner that allows for review prior to Saturday. Suggests improvements to these areas for review and approval by either the board, captains, or overall league where appropriate.

Current Officer: See the current League Board contact list.

Treasurer (If elected)

Duties: Responsibly creates budgets for the league to plan its expenditures and prize money distribution. Ensures collections of all fees and game money paid as well as ensures correct and prompt payout of all prizes. Suggests improvements to the resource allocation process for review and approval by either the board, captains, or overall league where appropriate.

Current Officer: See the current League Board contact list.

Tournament Director (If elected)

Duties: Plans for fun and fair tournaments of the game at the end of the season and as requested by the board for special events. The Tournament Director may also serve in an At-Large capacity when appropriate.

Current Officer: See the current League Board contact list.

Events Director (If elected)

Duties: Plans for all special events including but not limited to season opening, midseason, and end-of-season parties and social gatherings plus other events requested by the board. The Events Director may also serve in an At-Large capacity when appropriate.

Current Officer: See the current League Board contact list.

At-Large (If elected)

Duties: Assists the board with all duties as requested. Attends all meetings and offers advice, counsel, and input to aid and support the board where appropriate.

Current Officer: See the current League Board contact list.

Elections & Terms

Current officers are responsible for organizing a league meeting for the purposes of electing officers before the start of each season with enough time for proper organization of the season.

Potential officers and officers looking to be re-elected should be present at the organizational meeting, but it is not required if excused by a separate vote to allow for absentee candidates at the meeting in question.

Each member of the league that attends the election meeting may vote. No absentee voting or voting by proxy of any form is permitted.

Election of officers starts with Commissioner and proceeds down through the list. The current Commissioner handles running the actual elections proceeding. A candidate for office must be nominated by a member of the league present and must be seconded by another league member also present at the meeting.

An officer is elected by carrying the majority of votes as determined by the Commissioner. A challenge to the vote may be asked of the entire board if an election is disputed. A vote of the board present will then be taken to determine the proper action to determine the duly elected officer.

Officers are elected to one-year terms which end at the next election meeting the following year.

Officers may be removed from their roles by a majority vote of the board due to abandonment of duties, actions that put the good reputation of the league in jeopardy, or other similar reasons. Interim appointments may be made to fill a position if an emergency during a season already in progress. If those appointments occur before the middle of the season, they must be confirmed by a special election meeting that should occur at any midseason special event.

Meetings & Rule Changes

Meetings between the board and all team captains should be organized before the start of each season and in the middle of the season with the purpose of having enough time to communicate updates and pursue approvals of major initiatives and rules changes.

Changes to the rules of play or organizational bylaws must be approved by a majority of all captains.

Venue, Conduct & New Teams

No team may change its sponsor venue during the season unless:

1. The Venue goes out of business.

2. The Venue chooses not to further sponsor a team.

Player Banned from a Venue

If a player has been removed from or banned from a sponsor venue, the League Board will review the circumstances and determine whether league discipline is necessary. Shooters Pool League has no tolerance for violence, threats, harassment, or unsportsmanlike conduct directed toward players, league officials, or sponsor venues. Any disciplinary action should be based on documented conduct and communicated to the affected player.

New Teams. A new team may be added after the season begins. Makeup matches for a newly added team may not extend more than two weeks beyond the date the team enters the league unless the Board approves an exception.

Revision Reference

Game-rule references were reviewed against the current Official Rules of CueSports International used by the BCA Pool League. Shooters-specific local rules control where this document expressly differs.